

gress (TMC) chief and West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and her counterparts in Bihar and Jharkhand, Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) leader Nitish Kumar and Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) chief Hemant Soren, respectively, excused themselves, citing previous engagements. DMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam) supremo and Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin was busy with a different sort of turbulence: the devastation wrought by Cyclone Michaung. Mamata even publicly claimed that she was not consulted before the meeting was scheduled.

With their collective thumbs-down, the allies were seeking to convey a message to the Congress—that they would no longer tolerate any unilateral decision-making by the Grand Old Party. More so after its disastrous performance in the assembly polls, with Telangana, where the party trounced the incumbent Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) as the only saving grace. Earlier, the Congress had taken flak from the allies over not just the seat-sharing squabbles but also for stalling the alliance's momentum because of its preoccupation with the assembly polls. The tables had turned and now the others had little patience for it.

BREWING DISCONTENT

After its formation in June, INDIA has held three meetings, first in Patna in June, a second one in Bengaluru in July, and a third in Mumbai over August 30-September 1. Later in September, a 14-member coordination committee was set up to act as a top decision-making body to start work on seat-sharing. That, however, came to a stop as the